

BETTMANN ARCHIVE

Battle of Shalateng

(1947-48 war)

On October 22, 1947, Pashtun tribal militia crossed the boundary of the princely state of Jammu and Kashmir and advanced rapidly along the Jhelum valley. Unable to stop the raiders, Maharaja Hari Singh signed the Instrument of Accession, and the first unit of the Indian Army was airlifted to Srinagar on October 27. The gallant efforts of Lieutenant Colonel Ranjit Rai of 1 Sikh and Major Somnath Sharma of 4 Kumaon helped prevent the raiders from capturing the Srinagar airfield, which was vital for the build-up of Indian troops. On November 7, the Indian Army mounted its first offensive at Shalateng, about 15 km west of Srinagar. In a classic enveloping attack with infantry and armoured cars, supported by effective strafing by the Indian Air Force, the raiders were completely routed. They fled, with the Indian Army in pursuit. Within a week, areas up to Uri had been recaptured. The Kashmir valley was firmly in India's control.



Operation Bison: Tanks at Zoji la

(1947-48 war)

By August 1948, the situation in Ladakh was extremely precarious. Skardu garrison had fallen, and Leh was besieged. The route to Leh from Srinagar was cut off, with Pakistani troops occupying the 11,600 ft high Zoji La, Kargil, and Dras. The first attack on Zoji La, launched by 77 Para Brigade in September 1948, failed to dislodge the defenders. With winter approaching, the situation was critical, and it was decided to launch an audacious attack, employing Stuart tanks that were secretly moved from Jammu. After improving the track to Zoji La, the combined attack of infantry, tanks, and armoured cars was launched on November 1 amidst falling snow. The assault completely surprised the Pakistanis, and Zoji La fell in a few hours. This success paved the way for the capture of Dras and Kargil, and the Pakistanis retreated to Skardu. The route to Leh was open.

These three battles define the current geographies of the Kashmir, Jammu, and Ladakh regions. It is not difficult to imagine India's almost insurmountable geostrategic challenges if Poonch, parts of the Kashmir valley, or Leh were in Pakistani control today.